

recent tragedies. Closer integration with the operations of global counterparts, business process outsourcing and the emergence of call centres have made the 9-to-5 schedule impractical these days, and employees in many industries have to work in shifts or stay back till late in the night. Their safety and security until they reach home has become important for many companies. This is the inspiration behind Persistent Systems' new employee safety solution.

"Over one-third of our workforce at Persistent Systems is composed of women. We want to provide the best possible means to ensure their security, and technology can play an important role in that. Modern technologies, especially mobility, location services, and easy availability of content and information, have made it feasible for companies like us to look at building a solution that can reduce the risk for employees," says Shivesh Vishwanathan, senior consultant (Mobility), Persistent Systems.

While there are general security solutions available on mobile devices, they do not cater to employees specifically or to the Indian context. What companies need is a solution that is well-tailored to their needs.

"Our solution looks at the holistic picture for employee safety. The security staff keeps track of individual cabs and the route being taken by them. They can also be alerted in case of route deviations, etc. Notifications to a few emergency contact numbers and to the security are sent as SMS. Attention to detail and simplicity of user interface are critical for such applications to be useful and widely adopted. For example, with our app, the employee can shake the device in a particular movement to raise an alert in case of emergency," says Vishwanathan.

The solution has been built with a backend on Rails framework. The mobile app has been built for Android devices currently, and the iOS version is slated for release soon. The app uses the smartphone's GPS capability to identify location and integrates with

Google Maps on the backend for the user to define routes before leaving and show any deviations from the decided path to be taken by the cab.

The solution puts location, messaging and maps to innovative use by tracking the employee/cab location, recording route deviations and sending alerts in case of an emergency or distress.

"We have piloted the solution at Persistent and are currently rolling out the front-end mobile utility on Android devices for our employees in a phased manner. There are companies in Pune for whom we are customising the solution and running pilots," says Vishwanathan.

'Safety' orientation, across the mobile value chain

Social tags: eve-teasing, women safety
Tech tags: SOS button, mobile app, network services, SMS, GPS, social media

Last year saw quite a few solutions to handle eve-teasing smartly, and interestingly the options are spread across the value chain—built-in phone features, apps and network-level services.

One such solution is a simple mobile app called FightBack developed by value-added service provider CanvasM—a collaborative venture between Motorola and Tech Mahindra. FightBack is a small app that can be installed on Android, iOS, Windows and BlackBerry phones. A user simply needs to download the app and configure it with the required details. It uses GPS, SMS, location maps, GPRS email and the user's Facebook account to inform loved ones when the user is in trouble and presses a 'panic' button. The SOS alert also includes location details of the person in distress, so that people can rush to the rescue.

Going to show that network operators can also do their bit, Bharti Airtel announced an interesting safety tool for women, which can be setup initially by dialling the toll-free number 55100 from Airtel phones. The emergency alert solution allows customers to send an alert with their geographical

location to ten close contacts, with just one call, facilitating access to easy and quick help in times of need. Additionally, users can send a 'safe' message to the pre-defined group to periodically update them on their safety.

At the manufacturer level also, there are examples. The newly launched Jivi 2010 is targeted at Indian women and has a dedicated SOS button. This phone is priced at below ₹ 2000, in order to reach the masses. The solution is also quite easy to use. In case of an emergency, the user needs to press the SOS button for a few seconds, and the phone starts calling five pre-defined numbers one after the other. In case any of the numbers is busy or does not take the call, an SMS message is sent to it, before the phone proceeds dialling other numbers.

There is also a Mobile Tracker, which can be used to trace the person in need. The same feature can also be used to trace a lost phone. The phone also includes a folder lock feature so that unauthorised users cannot access the content in such folders.

Connecting educators to rural education centres

Social tag: Rural education, inclusive growth, skills development

Tech tags: Internet of Everything, cloud-driven platform, real-time interaction

As part of their Internet of Everything initiatives, Cisco's India centre recently launched a rugged and cost-effective remote education platform to facilitate rural education centres with access to top-class learning resources and expert educators. There is a gap in the quality of education in urban and rural centres and the aim of Cisco's Education Enabled Development (CEED 2700) solution, codenamed Dwara, is to bridge this gap by using their collaborative, cloud-based video interaction solution to deliver education and skills development courses across the country.

The main goal of this solution is to enable rural populations to access expert teachers and trainers. A teacher